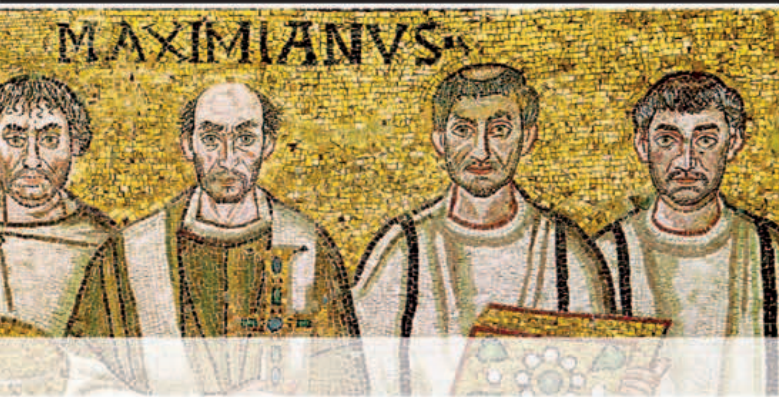




“THE **PLAGUE** FELL UPON THE WHOLE WORLD... NOT A SINGLE MAN IN THE WHOLE ROMAN EMPIRE COULD ESCAPE...”

Procopius, Byzantine scholar, from *Secret History*, c. 550



Justinian's reconquests

Vandal Italy fell to Justinian's armies in 533, but it was devastated by the 20-year war needed to take it. An attempted Byzantine reconquest of Spain foundered, capturing only a few coastal areas.

Persia entered a new period of greatness under **Khusrau I** (r. 531–79), who came to the throne at a time when the Mazdakites—a populist religious movement—had caused serious social tensions. Khusrau **reformed the tax system** and established a **new army**, encouraging poorer nobles

and their followers to serve by paying salaries. Khusrau **captured Antioch** in 540, forcing Justinian to pay 5,000 pounds of gold to regain it. He attacked again, in 544, but a siege of Edessa failed and so he made a truce. A further Byzantine–Persian war (546–51) resulted in a **50-year peace**.

THE LATTER PART OF JUSTINIAN'S REIGN lacked the achievements of its first half. A serious outbreak of **plague**, probably bubonic plague, began in Egypt in 540 and caused widespread mortalities, robbing the empire of desperately needed manpower. **Tax revenues fell**, further weakening the administration, and **prices rose**, leading to the passing of laws in 544 to reduce inflation. Further outbreaks of plague occurred in the 6th and 7th centuries, sapping the vitality of the Byzantine Empire.

In Italy, the **Ostrogoths** made rapid advances after the departure of **Belisarius**. Their new king, **Totila**, secured the area north of the Po River, and in 542 took control of much of central Italy. Belisarius was recalled to retrieve the situation in 544, but Justinian starved him of resources and **Rome fell** in 546. Although the Byzantines retook Rome in 547, it fell once more to Totila in 550. Justinian sent two huge armies under **Artabanes** and **Narses** to finish off the Goths. Artabanes entered Ravenna in June 552, and in July Narses defeated Totila at the **Battle of Busta Gallorum** in the Apennines. Totila later died of his wounds. There was still some Ostrogoth resistance, but the war in Italy was effectively over.

“TO ME, AND TO MANY OTHERS, **THESE TWO SEEMED NOT TO BE HUMAN BEINGS, BUT VERITABLE DEMONS... VAMPIRES.**”

Procopius, Byzantine scholar, on Justinian and Empress Theodora, from *Secret History*, c. 550



Ostrogothic brooch
This gold and enamel brooch demonstrates the high level of workmanship in the Ostrogothic kingdom of Italy. Its eagle imagery may indicate Roman influence.

